

Baroque art

The term "Baroque" describes a style of 17th-century European art. Rome, the centre of the Catholic church, was its birthplace. During the 16th century, the Christian church split into Roman Catholic and Protestant factions. By the 17th century, the Catholic church was using art to spread its teachings. To appeal to the viewer, it promoted a style of art that was theatrical and emotional. Painters were encouraged to use light and shade for dramatic contrasts, sculptors to show figures in dynamic poses. To achieve these effects, artists had to develop great technical skills.



Bernini

The Italian painter, sculptor, and architect Gianlorenzo Bernini (1598–1680) was an outstanding influence on Baroque art. He had an exceptional ability to convey great emotion and drama in stone, designed to inspire those who saw his work to greater faith. This sculpture depicts the vision of St. Teresa, in which an angel pierced her with an arrow.

Bernini, *The ecstasy of St. Teresa*, 1652



Caravaggio, *The Calling of St. Matthew*, c.1598–99

Light and shade

The Italian painter Michelangelo Caravaggio (1573–1610) shows the moment when Christ calls Matthew to become a disciple. A ray of light illuminates Matthew, but Christ is hidden by shadow.

Romanticism

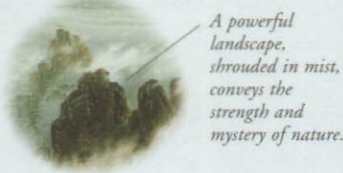
The early 19th century in Europe is known as the Romantic Age. It was, in part, a reaction to 18th-century art, which had emphasized balance and order. Romantic artists questioned the place of human beings in the Universe. They stressed the importance of human emotion and the imagination, and celebrated the wild power of nature in dramatic landscape paintings.



Friedrich, *Wanderer among the Mists*, 1818

The lonely universe

The German artist Caspar David Friedrich (1774–1840) was spiritually inspired by natural landscapes. There is an intense mysticism to this painting, as a solitary figure contemplates the mighty Alps.



A powerful landscape, shrouded in mist, conveys the strength and mystery of nature.

Change in the 19th century

From the mid-19th century, artists broke with the tradition established by earlier generations. Where they were once told what to depict by patrons, who paid them, they now produced what they wanted, and then tried to sell their work.



Camille Pissarro, *Place du Théâtre Français*, 1898

Selection of colours from Renoir's palette



Impressionism

This school of painting grew up in France in the late 19th century. Artists such as Camille Pissarro (1830–1903), Claude Monet (1840–1926), and Auguste Renoir (1841–1919) painted their impressions of a brief moment in time, in particular, the changing effects of sunlight. They were criticized at first, for viewers expected paintings to look more detailed, but have been very influential.

20th-century art

During the 20th century, artists explored new theories about the world, religion, and the mind. They asked the public to confront things that they might wish to ignore, and explored many different styles. After nearly 2,500 years, the grip of Classical art seemed to have been broken.

Surrealism

During the 1920s, the fantastical art made by the Surrealists explored theories about the way the brain works. New ideas had suggested that people consciously only used a tiny part of their brains, and that they were unaware of subconscious activity, over which they had no rational control. The bizarre, dreamlike paintings of Surrealists, such as the Spanish artist Salvador Dali (1904–89), were inspired by these ideas.



Salvador Dali



Abstract art

Abstract artists do not represent objects from the everyday world. Colour and shape alone suggest ideas or emotions. In this way, abstract art is like music: neither describe anything that can be defined in words, but both can be expressive and moving. The artists Jackson Pollock (1912–56) and Mark Rothko (1903–70) are two of the most famous abstract painters.

Jackson Pollock, *The Moon, Woman cuts the circle*, 1943

Modern art

Much modern art is specially created to be seen in a museum or gallery, and not for houses, palaces, or churches as in the past. It often prefers to baffle, tease, and provoke its audience, rather than make its meaning obvious.



Yoko Terauchi, *Air Castle*, 1994

Ambroise Vollard

The French art dealer Ambroise Vollard (1865–1939) made a living buying, selling, and exhibiting modern art. He gave early 20th-century artists unprecedented financial and creative freedom to paint as they wished. Artists such as Paul Cezanne and Henri Matisse achieved success in Vollard's gallery in Paris in the 1900s.

